

The **Battle** for Hue

Communist forces overran the city of Hue at the start of the Tet Offensive and held fast in Vietnam's ancient capital for nearly a month. US and ARVN forces fought street by street—and often hand-to-hand—to oust them.

◀◀ BEFORE

Hue became Vietnam's imperial capital in the early 19th century when Emperor Gia Long moved his royal court from Hanoi to the river city.

ROYAL ENCLAVE

Started in 1804, the **Citadel** was a fortress-palace complex surrounded by high walls and filled with palaces, temples, and gardens. It contained the Imperial City, where the **emperor and royal family** lived inside the Forbidden Purple Palace. Hue remained the royal capital until 1945, when **Emperor Bao Dai** abdicated and went to live in exile in Paris.

As the headquarters of the US military and the South Vietnamese government, Saigon was the primary objective of the Tet Offensive, but the ancient city of Hue was next in line. The city's imperial history made it highly symbolic, and in the eyes of the NVA and Viet Cong, capturing Hue would show the nation and the world that their struggle was against all forms of imperialism.

By the eve of Tet in 1968, some 10,000 Viet Cong guerrillas and NVA regulars had worked their way into clandestine positions all around the city. Synchronizing their attack with many others around South Vietnam, they launched their assault on Hue shortly after 2 a.m. on January 31. Disguised in ARVN uniforms, a small group of NVA soldiers tricked the guards and gained access through the western gate of the Citadel on the north side of the Perfume River. Communist troops poured into the sprawling royal compound on the hunt for South Vietnamese troops. Other battalions swarmed through the modern town on the south bank with the objective of disabling or destroying Hue's civilian government and any US military presence.

The city was even more lightly defended than Saigon. The attackers quickly captured most of their strategic objectives, including prisons where more than 2,000 political prisoners and 400 communist prisoners of war were being held. By daybreak, a Viet Cong flag was flying over the Citadel. Hanoi was able to claim that it had liberated a major South Vietnamese city for the first time.

“Hue is a **pleasant little town** with something of the leisurely air of a **cathedral city**.”

W. SOMERSET MAUGHAM, *THE GENTLEMAN IN THE PARLOUR*, 1930

Pockets of resistance

However, Hue was not completely in communist hands. A small detachment of US military advisers had barricaded themselves inside the compound of the MACV, in the commercial part of the city, and officers and clerks of the First ARVN Division had managed to repel the initial communist assault on their headquarters inside the Citadel. The third group that